prosperity. I say this with conviction as the present approach doesn't seem to be working out in the desired manner.

We need to have a careful look at the existing structure of our national security apparatus and defence management at the strategic level. The institutionalization of the military component of this apparatus in the 'decision-making loop' is unexceptional. This is to ensure that expert military advice is available to the national leadership and policy-makers, as is the case in major democratic nations. While formulating and conducting foreign policy, particularly in our fairly volatile neighbourhood and also in those countries where the military is all-powerful, military diplomacy and the views of the service chiefs can prove to be invaluable. Timely advice can help in the prevention of a security situation from snowballing out of control. In a few security-related situations in the past, the armed forces were not quite aware of the big picture or were caught unprepared or without having the desired readiness levels when asked to execute a mission. Such instances are not in the best interests of the nation and hence, should be scrupulously avoided as far as possible. An integrated team with officials from the services and the ministries of defence, external affairs, finance and home makes sense. More importantly, an integrated team within the army, navy and air force at the theatre commands and at the service HQs is required. As has been articulated in Part IV, once this model has matured over a few years, we could have in place a chief of defence staff with the operational responsibility of the armed forces and the accountability that goes with it.

A vital component of national defence is the indigenous capability to research, develop and produce critical high-technology defence systems such as combat aircraft, ships, submarines, tanks, missiles, rockets, unmanned aerial vehicles, electronic warfare systems, radars, sonars, armaments and strategic weapons. We should definitely look at joint development of some of these major weapon systems with other friendly countries as well, as no country can go it alone due to prohibitive research and developmental costs. It is a